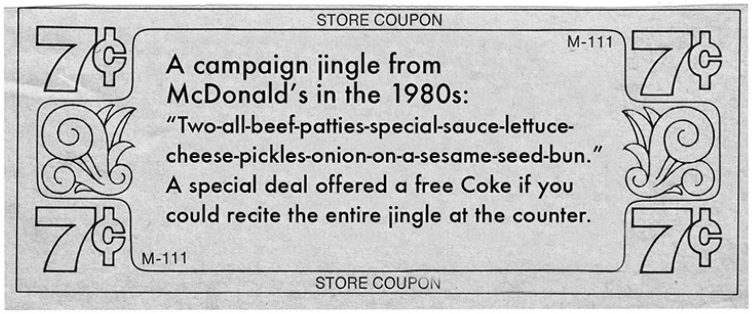

Sam Gold was right about one thing: children are good salesmen—perhaps too good. You might say that today's children are a marketer's best friend. According to a 2006 report from the Institute of Medicine, companies spend about seventeen billion dollars annually marketing to children. Not only that, children under fourteen spend about forty billion dollars annually and influence an additional five hundred billion dollars in purchases per year.

And while marketers might think that is great news, the general public—particularly parents—do not. A 2007 *Wall Street Journal* poll showed that 64 percent of people surveyed believe that popular characters should not be used to sell products to children. About half believe that marketing should be prohibited to children under the age of twelve.

Something Mr. Gold hadn't foreseen with his idea of marketing to youngsters was that all that television and all those premium promotions tied to junk food might result in a nation of fat children. Worry over our children's psyches and physical health has resulted in more and more restrictions put on marketers and advertisers. From the group "Campaign for a Commercial-Free Childhood," to the Federal Trade Commission's 2008 report, "Protecting America's Children," the consensus seems to be